

Supply lines were also tenuous. NVA units foraged on the march, procuring rice voluntarily from sympathetic peasants and taking it by force from those in opposition. Rations were meager and, compared to US infantry, North Vietnamese soldiers traveled light: a change of clothes, nylon tent and poncho, hammock, canteen, bowl and spoon, first-aid kit, ammunition pouch, and perhaps a week's worth of rice, as well as personal items such as photographs of family. They also carried machetes, shovels, flashlights, medical supplies, and weapons, though these were often in short supply. Injured and ill soldiers received treatment in jungle hospitals before returning to duty. For those too gravely wounded to fight any longer, the journey home—on stretchers carried by porters back up the Ho Chi Minh Trail—took several months and could prove fatal.



Joining the fight

During the 1950s and 1960s, artists often created works that served a propaganda purpose. This 1954 poster shows women and families saying goodbye to men leaving to fight in the NVA.

“Nothing is more **precious** than
independence and freedom.”

HO CHI MINH, AS FREQUENTLY QUOTED IN NORTH VIETNAMESE PROPAGANDA